▼ GLASSHOUSE



RAM VS SHIV VS RAVAN

Telangana chief minister **Revanth Reddy** can't seem to decide on Lord Ram. At an event in Delhi in September, he accused the BJP of obsessing over the Hindu deity, whom he described as the god of the rich. Shiva, he argued, was the lord of the poor, yet had been given the short shrift by the saffron party, with its incessant chanting of 'Jai Shri Ram' and scant invocation of 'Har Har Mahadev'. The saffron camp was quick to accuse Reddy of trying to "divide Hindus along religious and social lines". Yet, just days later, on October 11, Reddy chose to invoke Lord Ram at a rally in poll-bound Goa, casting the election as a battle between "Ravan (BJP) and Ram (Congress)". He warned that a split in the Opposition vote would benefit the former. So, while Reddy may pitch Shiva against Ram in the divine stakes, when it comes to electoral politics, Ram has the clear edge over Shiv-bhakt Ravan.

Illustrations by **SIDDHANT JUMDE**

▼ CROSS-CONNECTIONS

SHARED RELIANCE

Days after filing his Rajya Sabha nomination from Uttar Pradesh as a surprise nominee of the Samajwadi Party (SP), Reliance honcho **Dhanraj Parimal Nathwani** posted an effusive tribute to Prime Minister Narendra Modi on completing 25 years in public life. The praise presented an intriguing political contrast. On October 6, Nathwani had voiced concern over the detention of SP chief **Akhilesh Yadav** and other Opposition leaders in Delhi, stressing the importance of peaceful expression and democratic dialogue. Yet, he stopped short of questioning the BJP government. Nathwani's political connections make the episode more curious. His father, Parimal Nathwani, is a four-term independent Rajya Sabha MP backed by the ruling NDA. Many in the Opposition have questioned the SP's choice, but neither Nathwani nor Yadav have publicly explained this unusual political crossover, leaving plenty of room for speculation.

